Nitish Kumar government, of which the RJD was a part, had then raised the combined quota for Scheduled Castes (SCs), Scheduled Tribes (STs) and OBCs to 65 per cent. However, this 2023 legislation was struck down by the Patna High Court in June 2024, and the Supreme Court refused to overturn the ruling a month later. Now, with his demand to raise the quota ceiling even further, Tejaswi has doubled down on a contentious issue that has seen its potency challenged over the decades.

The assembly bypoll results have thrown a harsh spotlight on the RJD's waning dominance over its traditional Muslim-Yadav (M-Y) vote bank. In Belaganj, a seat it had held for 34 years, the party suffered its biggest setback. Here, Nitish's Janata Dal (United) had strategically fielded a Yadav candidate to eat into the RJD's core vote base. In Ramgarh, another RJD stronghold, senior leader Jagadanand Singh's son finished a distant third. Adding to the RJD's woes, high-profile campaigns led by Hena and Osama Shahab, widow and son respectively of the late *bahubali* Mohammed Shahabuddin, failed to reignite the party's fortunes. Although the RJD did secure four seats in the simultaneous Jharkhand assembly election, those are being ascribed more to Chief Minister Hemant Soren's popularity than any surge in Tejaswi's appeal.

The results have not only exposed fractures in the RJD's base but also reignited concerns within the INDIA bloc, particularly as they come just months before the 2025 Bihar assembly election. Analysts note that the Lok Sabha election held in mid-2024 already had the National Democratic Alliance (NDA), led by Chief Minister Nitish Kumar in the state, ahead in 177 of Bihar's 243 assembly segments—further compounding the Opposition's challenges.

But Nalin Verma, Lalu Yadav's biographer and a faculty member at Jamia Hamdard in New Delhi, downplays this, noting that state trends often buck national patterns, as seen in Maharashtra and Jharkhand. "A closer look at the bypoll results offers both a wake-up call and a blessing in disguise for Tejaswi and his RJD as they gear up for next year's assembly election," he adds.

Coming against this backdrop, Tejaswi's latest demand is widely seen as a strategic attempt to consolidate support among Bihar's marginalised communities. While the proposal is bold, its legal viability is highly questionable. For, the high court's decision to strike down the 65 per cent quota was based on constitutional limits, with the Supreme Court having historically capped reservations at 50 per cent.

The drawing power of the reservation plank has diminished in two ways. In the 1990s, these issues electrified Bihar's backwards as a unified spectrum; this consolidated base, from which the Lalu estate derived its once-imperial power, was first fragmented when Nitish sliced away the EBC segment within that. Today, moreover, a younger generation of voters is more focused on broader issues such as employment opportunities, economic development and education—areas where Bihar continues to lag.

Critics have dismissed Tejaswi's demand as more symbolic than substantive, a means to recast the RJD as a vanguard of social justice. But the symbolism may not be enough to counter the shifting priorities of Bihar's elector-

FRAUGHT WITH CHALLENGES



IN VAIN
Lalu Yadav campaigning in Belaganj, Nov. 11

- **Leader of the Opposition Tejaswi Yadav has proposed raising Bihar's quota limit to 85%, seeking to rally OBC and EBC support**
- **The RJD's bypoll defeats exposed fractures in its traditional Muslim-Yadav vote bank, which was nurtured by patriarch Lalu Yadav, and highlighted challenges from new entrants like Prashant Kishor's Jan Suraaj Party**
- **Even if it gets endorsed by the Nitish Kumar regime, Tejaswi's proposal will face legal barriers. The Patna High Court had struck down a similar attempt to raise the quota ceiling to 65%**

THE HOUSE OVERVIEW

The Bihar assembly composition after the bypolls

Total seats: 243

